



## CASE STUDY

# Concordia University Irvine Supports Admitted Student Success with Survey Research

Hanover Research helped Concordia University Irvine gather insights on admitted student success to improve student support and retention efforts.



CONCORDIA  
UNIVERSITY

### THE INSTITUTION

Concordia University Irvine

### INSTITUTION TYPE

Private undergraduate and  
graduate university

### LOCATION

Irvine, California

### THE CHALLENGE

Measure the efficacy of student  
support systems for provisionally  
admitted students

### HANOVER SOLUTION

Surveys, Qualitative Research

Concordia University Irvine (CUI) is a private, nonprofit Lutheran institution that enrolls more than 3,700 students at its three campuses in Southern California and online. As a Hispanic Serving Institution (HSI), the university received a federal grant to increase enrollment, early success, and graduation rates for Hispanic and low-income students.

## THE CHALLENGE: EVALUATE STUDENT SUPPORT STRATEGIES TO STRENGTHEN SUCCESS AND RETENTION

CUI leveraged the grant to enhance its student support services with success coaching, career counseling and faculty and staff professional development. CUI also developed a bridge program called WINGS that allowed first- and second-year students who don't meet traditional admissions standards to complete a summer bridge program before enrolling.

However, the university did not have a way to track the awareness or effectiveness of these various interventions, especially among provisionally admitted students. Without a clear understanding of how those services and programs were working, the university risked losing students with promising potential or falling short of grant expectations.

This led CUI leaders to partner with Hanover to conduct a thorough program impact evaluation and identify improvements.

“We wanted to do a study that combined quantitative and qualitative methods, and Hanover offered that. We got deeper and better information than we would have had without it. The study provided additional rationale for the university to invest in workforce readiness and career services.”

—Peter Senkbeil,  
Vice President and Special Assistant to the President



31%:

The percentage of enrolled  
students who are of Hispanic  
heritage

## THE SOLUTION: LEVERAGE QUANTITATIVE AND QUALITATIVE RESEARCH TO MEASURE EFFECTIVENESS AND IDENTIFY IMPROVEMENTS

Hanover designed a mixed-methods evaluation that combined **quantitative surveys** and **qualitative interviews** with key student groups to assess awareness, engagement, satisfaction, and unmet needs related to support services.

The survey provided CUI with a clear view of students' support service awareness, utilization, and satisfaction rates. The in-depth interviews further enriched that data with more detailed feedback from students. This comprehensive multi-modal approach provided CUI with deeper insights and actionable recommendations to enhance its support initiatives.

Data revealed that while students had high satisfaction rates for support services such as academic support and tutoring when they knew about them, many students were not aware that those and other services were available at all, despite previous outreach efforts.

To that end, the findings revealed prime opportunities for strategic communication and more assertive student outreach to boost awareness of services. Additionally, the qualitative research uncovered crucial insights about the importance of belonging and camaraderie among students of shared Hispanic heritage and experiences.

Finally, the data revealed key areas of unmet need related to specific student supports. For example, many students expressed a desire for greater access to mental health care, time management and study skill workshops, and disability support services.

---

“Hanover’s responsiveness and quality of work allowed us to take a more targeted approach to research about specific aspects of student success. The interventions seem to be working, though making students aware of some of these things is still harder than we thought.”

—Peter Senkbeil,  
Vice President and Special Assistant to the President

---

## THE OUTCOME: CONCRETE STRATEGIES TO IMPROVE STUDENT RETENTION

Hanover’s partnership helped CUI leaders attain a refreshed look at what it means to effectively support provisionally admitted students as a Hispanic Serving Institution. The research findings and recommendations led to several tangible improvements that CUI leaders are implementing, including:

- Increased communication efforts and channels to improve student awareness of services
- Expanded tutoring services and staff to meet student demand
- Enhanced workshops and activities for students to develop soft skills and build a deeper sense of belonging and connection

Moving forward, CUI plans to further refine and expand its support services and guide strategic success and retention decisions. By addressing the identified gaps and implementing the recommended actions, CUI is committed to fostering a supportive and engaging environment for all students.



**96%**

The percentage of provisionally admitted students who rate the writing support services as good or excellent



**47%**

The percentage of provisionally admitted students who were not aware of CUI’s career and vocation center